🗣️ “Safe Phrases” Cheat Sheet

Decision-first language for real project conversations
You don’t need all of these. Use **one or two at a time** — that’s enough to steer the project.

1️⃣ Opening the Conversation (Low-Risk Alignment)

Use these to redirect vague requests **without pushback**:

- **“Before we talk about solutions, I want to make sure I understand the decision this will support.”**
- **“Who will actually act differently once this exists?”**
- **“What’s the risk you’re most worried about getting wrong here?”**

🧠 *Why this works:* You’re framing clarification as **care**, not resistance.

2️⃣ When Stakeholders Ask for a Model Too Early

Instead of pushing back, say:

- **“A model might be part of this — but first I want to make sure we’re shaping uncertainty around the right decision.”**
- **“Let’s make sure we don’t over-engineer this before we understand the risk surface.”**
- **“There are a few ways this could fail quietly — I want to surface those first.”**

🧠 *Why this works:* You’re not rejecting modeling — you’re **sequencing it responsibly**.

3️⃣ Surfacing Constraints Without Sounding Negative

- **“What constraints should we treat as non-negotiable from day one?”**
- **“Even if the data suggests it, are there actions we wouldn’t be able to take?”**
- **“Which parts of this decision need to stay human?”**

🧠 *Why this works:* Constraints become **design inputs**, not blockers.

4️⃣ Talking About Data Quality Without Blame

Avoid:
“The data isn’t great.”
Use instead:

- **“I want to understand how much trust we should place in each input.”**
- **“Which signals do you rely on most today — even if they’re imperfect?”**
- **“Where do we already know the data can mislead us?”**

🧠 *Why this works:* You're validating reality, not criticizing systems or teams.

5️⃣ Introducing Uncertainty (Without Losing Credibility)

- **"There are a couple of assumptions baked into this that we should make explicit."**
- **"This works well as long as X stays true — if that changes, we'll want to revisit it."**
- **"This reduces uncertainty, but it won't eliminate it."**

🧠 *Why this works:* You're **setting expectations**, not hedging.

6️⃣ Framing Cleaning & Feature Choices Safely

Instead of:
"We need to clean the data."
Say:

- **"There are a few ways to shape this data, depending on which risks we want to avoid."**
- **"This choice trades early warning for stability — is that what we want here?"**
- **"Once we do this, we're committing to a particular interpretation."**

🧠 *Why this works:* You're making tradeoffs visible **before they're locked in**.

7️⃣ When You Need Time (Without Sounding Slow)

- **"Before moving forward, I want to pressure-test our assumptions so we don't have to redo this later."**
- **"This is a good moment to pause and make sure we're collapsing uncertainty in the right order."**
- **"A small delay here avoids much larger rework downstream."**

🧠 *Why this works:* You're optimizing for **speed over the whole project**, not just this step.

8️⃣ Defining Scope (Preventing Creep)

- **"This will help with X, but it won't answer Y — and that's intentional."**
- **"If we try to make it do both, we'll weaken the decision support."**
- **"Let's be explicit about what this is *not* deciding."**

🧠 *Why this works:* Explicit non-goals feel **professional**, not restrictive.

9️⃣ Handing Off to Production-Oriented Teams

- **"These assumptions are fine for now, but they're the ones we'll need to lock down later."**

- **“Here’s where this system could fail quietly — that’s where we should monitor.”**
- **“This is a decision-support tool, not an automated decision.”**

🧠 *Why this works:* You’re already speaking **production-native language**.

🔑 The One Phrase That Covers Almost Everything

If you remember only one, make it this:

“I want to make sure we’re solving the right decision problem before we optimize the solution.”

That sentence will:

- slow things down *just enough*
- earn trust
- keep you out of redesign hell

How to Practice (Low Pressure)

- Pick **2–3 phrases** that feel natural to you
- Use them consistently across projects
- Let stakeholders react — then adjust
- You don’t need to explain the framework behind them

You’ll sound thoughtful, not theoretical.

Where This Fits in the Big Picture

These phrases are how you:

- protect early pipeline decisions
- avoid irreversible mistakes
- apply AI-native reasoning in human conversations
- bridge school-taught DS with real-world systems work

You now have:

- a **decision-first mental model**
- a **kickoff checklist**
- a **safe language layer**

That combination is rare — and extremely powerful.

When you’re ready, we can:

- return to **Module 3’s mini-exercise** with this lens
- create a **one-page kickoff template** you can reuse
- map these phrases to **common failure scenarios**

Just tell me where you’d like to go next.